

Speaking Out

The junkification of research

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Abstract

This essay considers the emergent phenomenon of ‘junkification’ in academic research publishing. The term junkification was originally coined to describe the increasing volume of low-quality content and products permeating digital platforms. Extending junkification to online academic publishing, we draw on literature that frames academic research as an increasingly commodified good. We theorise that this commodification has enabled the same mechanisms that underpin the shift to junkification in digital marketplaces (and their subsequent degradation) to permeate online academic publishing. We argue that this trend represents a further perversion of the long-standing and pervasive ‘publish or perish’ culture in academia. As commercial publishing interests converge with new technologies, a system emerges where scholars increasingly bear the costs of low-esteem publishing that limits genuine scholarly contributions. We analyse the structural and cultural shifts within academic publishing that facilitate and perpetuate the junkification of research, and call for a re-evaluation of the underlying values and practices sustaining scholarly communication to counteract this trend.

Publishing in premier journals with high impact factor and Q1 journals: Dos and Don'ts

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Abstract

The evolving landscape of the academic world has ushered in a plethora of challenges and opportunities for researchers. While there are undoubtedly monetary incentives and fringe benefits for those who actively engage in publishing, the journey toward acceptance by a premier journal is often arduous and time-consuming. Considering this context, this paper endeavors to dissect prevailing trends, elucidate the reasons behind manuscript rejections, and furnish a compendium of strategies and insights aimed at augmenting the likelihood of acceptance while mitigating the probability of rejection.

KEYWORDS

journal, peer review, publishing, Q1 journals, rejection

1 | INTRODUCTION

Academia presents a dual nature akin to a coin with two distinct sides: heads and tails. With the escalating emphasis on research, numerous universities have adopted journal publications as a primary criterion for faculty selection and promotion. This places immense pressure on PhD students, assistant professors, and associate professors to secure publication in journals boasting high impact factors or Q1 categorization—the so-called premier journals. Some universities provide monetary incentives for publication.

The adage “Publish or Perish,” (Harzing, 2010), has transcended borders and become a reality even in developing countries. Concurrently, a new maxim has emerged in academic circles: “Publish and Prosper.”

Traditionally, a professor's role is primarily that of an educator, with research playing a secondary role. However, the prevalent Western model, exemplified by the R1 research-oriented university system in the United States and echoed in numerous other countries, tends to prioritize a professor's role as a researcher over that of a teacher. Moreover, some research-centric universities in the United States predicate tenure considerations on publications in a select few

journals within a given field over a specific period, typically 5–6 years, while the probationary period is just 1 or 2 years in many Asian or European Universities.

The crux of the matter lies in determining the criteria by which universities gauge journal quality. How do universities discern which journals merit inclusion on their official lists for promotion and tenure evaluations?

This prompts a critical inquiry into the methodologies employed by universities to assess journal quality and relevance. Decisions regarding journal inclusion for promotion and tenure considerations often hinge on established rankings and metrics tailored to each discipline. These metrics may encompass factors such as impact factor, citation indices, peer review rigor, editorial board stature, and journal reputation within the academic community.

Universities must strike a delicate balance between recognizing the significance of research output and maintaining the integrity of academic scholarship. It is incumbent upon academic institutions to devise transparent and equitable evaluation frameworks that uphold scholarly rigor while fostering a supportive environment conducive to both teaching and research excellence.

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Journal quality and rank is a debatable topic as different journals are ranked in different ways by different agencies/committees in different countries. Worldwide classification of journals is carried out yearly by Web of Science (WOS) and Scopus, that is, journals are ranked by WOS every year based on impact factor in subject categories with a number rank. In addition, WOS classified journals based on Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q4 based on the citations on WOS. On the other hand, journals are ranked as Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q4 by Scopus too. Schimago, awards values for journals every year based on a formula that considers citations of the articles published in historically prestigious journals. Most universities in countries such as Spain, Turkey, Gulf Co-operation Council countries such as the United Arab Emirates, China, and so on follow Q1, Q2, and Q3 systems of WOS. At the same time, in some countries, they have their own list, which gets revised once in 3 or 4 years. For example, the Australian Business Deans Council (ABDC), the UK Association of Business Schools (UK-ABJ), the Journal list of the Polish Ministry of Science and Higher Education 2023-Poland, Italy's ANVUR, FNEGE list of France, and so on. On the other hand, there are some lists that have not yet been updated for many years. Ex. UT Dallas list and FT-50 list have become somewhat outdated as they do not recognize the performance of journals based on the year-to-year dynamics. On the other hand, many Business schools in Asia and Australia, blindly follow ABDC list while considering the performance of their faculty members, while Journal Quality List of UK-Association of Business Schools (ABS) has been adopted in several European countries. Universities in Spain, Turkey, China, Arabic countries, India, and so on, recognize criteria such as Q1 journals on WOS. Scopus classification of journals has wide acceptability in developing countries.

Publishing in a journal with high impact factor/premium journal is a multifaceted challenge. Therefore, those who have information, knowledge, ideas, knowledge, expertise, and experience tend to have relatively high probability of acceptance. It is said that "Crafting an article" for a premium journal is an art and science at the same. In this context, this article provides specific suggestions for doing when you develop a research paper for an esteemed journal. In addition, we provide certain—Dos and Don'ts, which authors can use as a checklist.

In the following section, the common reasons for rejection in well-known international journals are outlined after defining them. Subsequently, section 3 provides information and tips that help you to minimize the probability of rejection and maximize the likelihood of acceptance.

2 | REASONS FOR REJECTION

What are the reasons for rejection in different journals? What do the editors and reviewers of the premium journals prefer, while selecting articles? Why do they reject more than 50% (Some journals in the areas of Business Management, Economics, and Social Sciences desk reject over 70% or even 80% submissions, while desk rejection rate in Engineering and Natural science journals is substantially low) of submissions?

The reasons for rejection in academic journals can vary significantly depending on the discipline, journal, and specific circumstances. However, several common factors contribute to manuscript rejections across various fields. Those reasons are outlined below.

2.1 | Lack of originality and uniqueness

Originality and uniqueness are very important in all fields of research. Journals are interested in pioneering articles from researchers. Researchers should be able to highlight the importance of their original work in the introduction section. Editors and reviewers seek manuscripts that present novel findings or insights that significantly contribute to the existing body of knowledge. Manuscripts deemed to lack originality are often rejected.

2.2 | Lack of scholarly presentation

The authors need to learn the art of writing a scholarly article based on citations and references from international journals. Some authors heavily source citations from web sites, edited books, magazines, newspapers, and so on, which are not considered as "Scholarly." That your reference list shows the standard of your research article. Reviewers often criticize when references are from sources that are not peer-reviewed because such sources are not considered scientific. It is important to include recent references from different journals to demonstrate that you have done original work, which others have not yet done.

2.3 | Insufficient impact

Most of the journals, prefer to select articles that get downloads and citations. Therefore, they prefer research papers that are likely to be read by people from different countries (Paul & Bhukya, 2021). This implies that papers with generalized lessons and insights are likely to be sent out for review.

2.4 | Flawed design

Many experts, including editors and reviewers, reject research articles when they have a flawed design. Experimental designs are increasingly popular in Marketing research these days, while single survey-based research is not considered as robust and appropriate in premier marketing journals. Some researchers develop papers with flawed design/methodology. For example, authors should have multiple studies instead of single experiment, when they have an experimental design.

Similarly, time series data analysis is popular method in Finance and Economics research. Nevertheless, authors are supposed to do bias checks such as Common Method Bias in cross-section data-based studies and multicollinearity in time series studies.

2.5 | Flawed methodology

Appropriate methodology is important in research. Authors should choose the best possible methodology for their research. Whenever they have confusion, it would be better if they consult with experts, statisticians, seniors, and so on, to finalize their methodology. Reliability and validity tests are required when you have a research article based on data analysis. On the other hand, when you have a systematic literature review or an article aiming for advancing a concept/construct or theory development, authors are required to follow certain protocols and procedures such as SPAR-4-SLR (Paul, Lim, et al., 2021; Paul, Merchant, et al., 2021). In conceptual articles, propositions serve the purpose of hypotheses, and such propositions need to be derived in such a way that others can test them as hypotheses in future research studies, that is, such propositions should be derived precisely like a hypothesis based on prior studies.

2.6 | Unsupported results

In an empirical research article, hypotheses are important regardless of the method authors have followed. For example, in both experimental and survey-based studies, authors need to derive testable hypotheses based on the findings of prior studies. Ideally, the results should support the hypotheses. Reviewers tend to reject research articles when results do not provide empirical evidence to support hypotheses.

2.7 | Poor writing or lack of flow or language quality problem

Clarity and coherence in writing are essential for effective communication of research findings. Manuscripts marred by poor grammar, convoluted language, or unclear organization might get rejected on the grounds of readability and comprehensibility.

The majority of the research articles are authored by non-native English speakers. It is important to understand that authors need to refine their work like a diamond. Otherwise, probability of rejection is high. In case, if an author does not have the required language skills, it would be prudent to hire a freelance English editor to improve the article before submitting it to the journal. Sometimes, authors do not have enough time to read and re-read (write and re-write). In such a situation too, authors should get their paper language edited and proofread before submission because journals have an acceptance rate of 3%–10% these days, depending upon the impact factor, rank of the journal.

2.8 | Narrow topic

Topic needs to be broad enough. When we edited a special issue of *Journal of Business Research*, our co-editor from a university in Missouri, United States, was very particular in desk rejecting manuscripts

submitted based on narrow topics because such papers do not get enough readers. The very purpose of running a journal is not served when a journal publishes an article on a very narrow topic. This implies that your topic should be broad enough. However, authors should avoid working on “too broad” topics.

2.9 | Unscientific content

Scientific content is critical while submitting to journals. This implies your text should be referenced to scientific journals with reputation, instead of web sites and internet sources.

2.10 | Plagiarism/similarity and self-plagiarism

It is important to check the similarity percentage before you submit your work in journals. There are several software such as Turnitin, iThenticate, and Grammarly for doing this task. Ideally, overall similarity should be less than 20% and single source similarity should be less than 2%. However, there are hard and fast rules in this regard with reference to similarity percent. Editors will tend to reject your paper if the similarity percentage is high. There were several papers rejected for these reasons during my tenure as Editor-in-Chief, *International Journal of Consumer Studies*.

2.11 | Outdated literature review

As many researchers run short of time, because of its time-consuming nature, some of them tend to copy literature reviews from previously published papers and paraphrase them. Nowadays, Generative Artificial Intelligence tools such as Chat GPT facilitates the development of literature review section to some extent. Journal editors and reviewers tend to reject many papers because of outdated literature review sections and outdated citations in the introduction.

2.12 | Lack of conceptual/theoretical contribution

Based on own experience as an author with 280 publications in 100 plus journals, and based on 4000 plus rejections received from journals, it is important to state that journal editors reject papers when they find that there is no conceptual/theoretical contribution in a research article. Theoretical/conceptual contribution is expected in almost all disciplines in research. Researchers need to learn the art of writing an article based on generalization, which in turn, leads to conceptual contribution.

2.13 | Replete research topic

Researchers need to understand that the probability of rejection is high when they do research on replete and recycled topics. It

is always better to select a topic with newness and novelty. Journals often ask a fundamental question—What is new in your article?

2.14 | Scope and audience

Journals have specific scopes and domains. Research studies submitted must align within the subject areas covered by the specific journal. Submissions not falling under the purview of the target journal may be rejected for “Out of Scope” reason.

2.15 | Low-quality data source

Reliable data sources are also important. Some premier journals reject manuscripts when authors use data from M-Turk or Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) stating that credibility of those agencies is debatable.

2.16 | High volume of submissions

Many journals in Business management, social sciences, and other disciplines receive thousands of submissions every year. For example, Journal of Business Research received over 8000 submissions in 365 days, while International Journal of Consumer Studies received 2500 manuscripts in the year 2023. At the same time, Journal of Consumer Research and Marketing Science received over 750 and 600 manuscripts, respectively, in 2023.

2.17 | Stringent standards

Premier Journals tend to maintain the highest standards to ensure the best quality necessitating three or four rounds of rigorous review processes, resulting in a higher proportion of rejections.

2.18 | Suspected manipulation in tables/results

Some papers get rejected when editors/reviewers develop suspicious minds about the content in the tables, statistical significance levels, incorrect information reported in tables, and so on. Many authors report incorrect information about most cited papers and most cited authors in Bibliometric reviews by including irrelevant papers in their database knowingly or unknowingly.

3 | THE ART OF ACADEMIC WRITING

A published manuscript usually begins with an introduction and proceeds through literature review, then hypotheses, then research methodology and analysis, then findings, and, finally, discussion and

conclusions (LaPlaca et al., 2018). In this context, this section provides ideas for increasing the probability of acceptance of your article in a premier journal.

3.1 | Abstract—The art of writing a structured abstract: Craft it properly

Abstract should be precise and short. Most journals have 150 words limit for the abstract. Therefore, it should be ideally, maximum five sentences including purpose of the study, brief outline of design and methodology of the study, findings, and the original contribution. Stating the purpose of the study perfectly and briefly is the first step. Authors need to highlight the original contribution of the paper in a precise sentence, while summarizing the findings of the study in another sentence.

3.2 | The art of writing—Introduction

Introduction should highlight the importance of the topic. Research gaps should be identified based on recent studies from different premier journals, in the subsequent paragraphs. The need for your study should be demonstrated and highlight what is new and unique in your article. Since premier journals are targeting global audience, it would be prudent if authors highlight the importance of their topic instead of focusing on their study's country or industry context, in the introduction. Context can be mentioned, but no need for highlighting it in the introduction. After crafting this section, make sure that you read and re-read this section five times before you submit the article to a journal.

3.3 | Title

Authors need to pay attention to have a “generalized and short” title because articles with generalized and precise titles get more downloads and readers. Better, avoid long and confused titles.

3.4 | Art of writing literature review section

Authors need to identify gap for their research based on prior studies and demonstrate the need for their study based on review of literature. Therefore, they need to carry out literature review of similar papers from different journals. Findings of other studies need to be highlighted, and studies with similar findings could be pooled together in this section. Authors need to include maximum recent studies and demonstrate that others have not done this type of study and therefore this new research study is original and unique. It would be prudent to follow a protocol like Scientific Procedures and Rationale for Systematic Literature Review (SPAR-4-SLR) (Paul, Lim, et al., 2021; Paul, Merchant, et al., 2021) for literature review regardless of

whether it is an empirical study or qualitative study or a mixed method work. Authors are advised to read and refer guiding articles and editorials in this regard (Paul & Criado, 2020; Paul & Menzies, 2023; Paul, Ueno, et al., 2023) for assembling, arranging, and assessing the articles based on the journal selection criteria article selection criteria. Bhukya et al. (2022) provide some ideas for setting future research agendas in review articles.

3.5 | Discussion section: Master the art of writing

Discussion section can be broadly classified under the following sub-sections.

3.5.1 | Findings of the study

This sub-section is important in all types of research papers (qualitative, quantitative, or mixed method studies). Presenting key findings precisely offers a quick insight into the research outcomes. This is important for engaging the readers and highlighting the importance of research.

3.5.2 | Implications for theory

Research studies are likely to get more readers and downloads when there are generalized insights from those studies. Theory comes from generalization. Authors need to keep in mind that they develop a sub-section on Theoretical implications, in their work. Theoretical contribution is expected from all types of research, and it is considered as vital.

3.5.3 | Implications for practice or implications for managers

After describing the theoretical insights, describe the implications of the study for managers and practitioners. This approach ensures logical flow and helps increasing the probability of acceptance in a competitive academic world. This sub-section should be directly based on the findings of the study and should convert the findings into practicable recommendations for managers.

3.5.4 | Limitations and directions for future research

Research studies are subject to limitations. Those limitations can be described in one paragraph. For example, intentional and self-reported data, small sample size, and so on, are considered as limitations.

Limitations should result in providing ideas for future research. At least two or three paragraphs should be dedicated for providing

directions for future research with reference to constructs, variables, methods, and theories. Paul and Bhukya (2021) provide ideas and details for developing the section on directions for future research.

3.6 | Art of writing conclusion

Conclusion should be ideally, just one or two paragraphs. It should be written in author's own words, without references. It should be the summary of the paper highlighting the findings of the paper. It is not merely the final section, but the outcome of the research. It is important as it reinforces the significance of the research.

3.7 | Topic with newness and novelty

It makes sense to do research on current/contemporary topics because they are neither replete nor recycled. Topics evolve from time to time. For example, when social media was emerging as an important phenomenon, people who ventured into research in different areas of social media, were able to easily get their papers accepted in different journals, being first movers. Such articles emerged as the most downloaded and cited articles too, again because of the First Mover advantage. For example, Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) were among the first mover researchers on social media and their conceptual article published in Business Horizons published in 2010 has received over 33,000 citations within 14 years as on April 2, 2024.

Similarly, when COVID-19 turned out to be a global issue, researchers who did work on different dimensions of COVID-19 pandemic not only got their papers accepted but also, received substantial number of citations for their work. First and Fast mover researchers in an emerging area with a new subject topic have more opportunities to get their articles accepted and cited. For example, researchers who ventured into researching social media (when it was emerging as a major phenomenon) got not only their works accepted in known journals, but also got lot of citations in the same way Uber leveraged and capitalized the opportunities as a first mover in ride-sharing industry. First and fast mover researchers on COVID-19, Artificial Intelligence including Chat GPT got many citations. Sheth (2020) was one of the first mover authors to write about the COVID and consumer behavior and his invited article in Journal of Business Research received over 2300 citations within 4 years. Dwivedi et al. (2023) and Paul, Khatri, and Kaur Duggal (2023); Paul, Ueno, and Dennis (2023) were the first movers to write about Chat GPT and their articles have received hundreds of citations within a year itself. This can be taken as evidence to state that First Movers have an advantage not only in the industries, but also in academia.

3.8 | Inclusion of co-authors

Since the majority of the universities do not have a system to encourage authors of single-authored papers, in a better way than

researchers co-authoring; identifying, and including co-authors based on either complementary skills or subject expertise make sense in research. Authors can look at the reference list and identify whose papers are cited more and approach them as co-authors.

Even though it is not ethical, based on the observation of articles published in many premier western journals, some journals tend to accept articles submitted by authors from well-known universities. Nevertheless, it has become a fashion in some journals to have one or two co-authors from premier universities as co-authors to get the paper accepted, though it is neither an ethical nor an encouraging trend.

The easy way to be a successful academician is to do a PhD from a reputed university under the supervision of a professor with track record and reputation. However, many people from developing countries, did not have the information, resources, and guidance at the right time in their lives to apply and try for such doctoral programs with fellowships. For people who do not have a PhD degree from a prestigious university, it would be important for working hard throughout their first 15 years after the PhD if they want to establish themselves as successful researchers. Another unethical trend in the field is a common activity that editorial board members, including associate editors and special issue editors, are publishing frequently in the journals where they serve as associate editors or special issue editors. In addition, these two facts discourage the ordinary people from ordinary universities or demotivate people from developing countries to submit their work in premier journals/journals with high impact factor.

Including the office bearers of the society who run the journals as co-authors or editorial board members as co-authors help an ordinary author to increase his chances. However, junior authors need to be active in conferences to meet with such senior authors to seek and get their consent as co-authors. Otherwise, senior professors tend to decline cold call invitations as co-authors. This would necessitate investment of time, effort, and money for travel and networking. These are realities of life in academia. A remark of a father of a PhD student in engineering field is quoted below “My son is doing PhD under an influential professor in Texas. His papers are easily getting accepted because his supervisor's name itself is good enough to get the paper accepted.” This trend is common in Business management and social sciences disciplines too. However, it is important to note that this does not always guarantee an acceptance, particularly in this journal.

4 | DOs

Based on the above-mentioned points, it makes sense to provide specific DOs and Don'ts as checklist to avoid the probability of rejections and increase the chances of acceptance. These suggestions are based on the vast experience as Editor-in-Chief for 4 years handling 10,000 plus submissions for International Journal of Consumer Studies, Associate Editor of Journal of Business Research for 3 years (2019–2022), Associate/Senior Editor of European Management Journal, European

Management Review, Journal of Strategic Marketing, and International Journal of Emerging Markets. Experience as an author of 200 plus journal articles based on several rejections and acceptances has also helped in crafting these suggestions.

1. Do plagiarism check before submission.
2. Refine your paper many times and develop it like a Diamond.
3. Follow generalized approach.
4. Focus on the contemporary importance of your topic instead of highlighting the context.
5. Include recent references from all the target journals to identify research gap.
6. Do original research with newness and novelty.
7. Design Mixed Method studies instead of a single study wherever possible.
8. Do robustness checks such as Common method bias, multicollinearity depending on the type of data.
9. Invite co-authors from well-known institutes or co-authors who have published on the same topic or from the editorial board of the journals.
10. Be either a first mover researcher or a Fast mover to work on a current topic.
11. Develop a precise, yet comprehensive manuscript.
12. Learn the art of writing short sentences instead of long and confusing sentences.
13. Focus on your topic in the title and Introduction.
14. Ensure that manuscript is perfect with conceptual/theoretical contribution.
15. Ensure that manuscript is perfect with reference to Analytical and Presentation Dimensions.
16. Develop your empirical paper after carrying out multiple studies with behavioral data.
17. Get it English edited and proofread by someone else.
Derived hypotheses in an empirical paper; research questions (RQ) in a qualitative paper and theoretical/testable propositions in a conceptual paper.
18. In the Discussion section, try to corroborate/contrast your findings with the findings of similar studies (if any).
19. Check Word length permitted by the target journals. Even though some journals have strict Word length like 6000 or 8000 or 12,000 words, several journals have become flexible these days.
20. Go for experimental studies if you are in Marketing Management domain. Experimental design and method have greater probability of acceptance in many other subject areas too. Please refer to Stoner et al. (2023) if you are doing an experimental design-based study to learn about best practices. Other sources of reference for classic experimental studies are Sung et al. (2023) and Khan-deparkar et al. (2024), published in International Journal of Consumer Studies.
21. Please download and read it. Crick (2021) from Journal of Strategic Marketing if you are doing a Qualitative study.
22. Go for co-variance-based Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) (if you do SEM methodology, instead of Partial Least Square

(PLS)-SEM). See the guiding article by Dash and Paul (2021) published in *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* in this regard. However, some journals reject single studies regardless of whether you use CB-SEM or PLS-SEM, if you just have one study in your paper.

23. Think about doing two studies in the same paper as study 1 and study 2. For example, study 1 using SEM, preferably CB-SEM methodology and study 2 using Fuzzy Set Qualitative Comparative Analysis (FSQCA). Necessary Condition Analysis (NCA) can also be carried out. Researchers without expertise in FSQCA or NCA, can refer to the article by Diwanji (2023) and Olya et al. (2022) published in *International Journal of Consumer Studies*.
24. Do Mixed method studies using behavioral data (see Venkatesh et al. (2016) in *MIS Quarterly*).
25. Ensure Theoretical Contribution in Review Articles: Some researchers develop different types of review articles. Please make sure that you develop a classic review with theoretical contribution, should you decide to spend time on review papers. For example, refer to Paul and Mas's (2020) "Towards a 7-P Framework for International Marketing" if you are developing a conceptual review aiming for theory development based on literature review. Similarly, Teece (2007) developed—Dynamic capability theory—in a conceptual review published in *Strategic Management Journal*. Another recommendation for researchers who are interested in developing impactful systematic literature review articles is to refer to guiding articles in this regard (Paul & Criado, 2020; Paul, Merchant, et al., 2021; Paul, Lim, et al., 2021; Paul & Menzies, 2023; Paul, Ueno, et al., 2023).
26. Target Special issues if you are an early career researcher: Acceptance rate is relatively high in Special issues compared with regular issues. Researchers must pass the desk rejection screening at two stages/levels in regular issues (by an Editor-in-chief/senior editor and another associate editor) while it is normally screening by one special issue editor in special issues. Many special issues do not get hundreds of submissions, while regular issues get thousands of submissions these days. Some tier 2 journals such as *Information System Frontiers*, *Journal of Consumer Behavior*, and so on, have launched many special issues, while top journals launch special issues rarely.

5 | DON'Ts

This section provides specific suggestions to keep in mind while developing and submitting different types of papers to journals based on the vast experience of this author. They can be listed as follows.

1. Avoid working on Students' sample because many journals have a policy of rejecting such papers.
Premier journals reject studies based on student samples. For example, British Journal of Management submission portal has guidelines to discourage such studies.

2. Do not undertake studies using Convenient Sampling and snow-ball sampling.

Many journals desk reject research studies based on convenient sampling and snow-ball sampling. For example, the standard desk rejection letter from *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services* has this information.

3. Do not work on small-size samples while developing empirical research articles.

Inferences based on the findings/results of analysis based on small sample size are likely to be spurious and biased. Such results would not represent the population. Therefore, avoid spending your time when you have studies based on small samples.

4. Do not defend if you get revision.

Getting revision from a premier business/social science journal is the case only in about 5%–7% of manuscripts submitted. Therefore, implement maximum comments from reviewers, and treat them like your business/life partner. Defending like an army/navy/air force staff is not likely to result in an acceptance because reviewers have the right to reject your manuscript even after one or two rounds of revisions.

5. Do not spend all your time to change your reference formats.

After Elsevier implemented the Free format (Your paper your own way), policy, other journal publishers and editors have become flexible in this regard. Therefore, no need to spend your valuable time to change the reference format for your next journal submission. Authors had it tough to change reference format till recently. Wide experience of submitting to different journals as an author gives me insights to infer that there are 2%–3% of journals still looking for the first submission to be in their formats such as American Psychological Association (APA) or Harvard format.

6. Do not work on a topic when there are already 1000 papers published on the same topic.
7. Better, do not add country and state name of your context as part of the title and introduction.
8. Avoid extraneous information.
9. Avoid intentional and self-reported data. Papers based on such data/models are often rejected.
10. Avoid citations from local/unknown/predatory journals.
11. Avoid citations from web sites, if possible.
12. No need to include country/state/region/city name in the title because you need a generalized and concise title.
13. Do not submit to slow journals. Elsevier and Wiley web sites have Journal Finder tool that shows matching journals with the information of matching journal's Impact Factor, Average processing Time, and so on. Springer discloses this data on each journal web site.
14. Never get disappointed if journals reject your paper. While acceptance rate is relatively high in Science and Technology journals, such outlets in the field of social sciences including business management have an acceptance rate of 2%–10%.
15. Avoid mere bibliometric reviews if you are writing a review article because such reviews have no theoretical contributions.